the walls were part of a still-unknown cultural or religious project. Asko Parpola, a Harappan Civilization scholar and author of *The Roots of Hinduism* (2015), has suggested that their purpose may 'have been to impress people and thus reinforce political power'.[17] Unfortunately, not much can be said here with certainty about what drove their need for such massive fortifications.

Indeed, Dholavira's gigantic reservoirs and fortification walls are its monumental works, rivalling the Pyramids of Giza in ambition, effort, design planning and mobilization of labour. The Herculean civil engineering makes one wonder what drew Dholavirans to this hostile arid land in the first place (maybe it was much less arid in 3000 BCE, as has been proposed), and how much collective thought and energy went into the hydraulic projects. It must have required a large labour force and a centralized bureaucracy. Notably, Harappan cities offer no evidence of slave labour, nor 'depictions of people being bound or captured',[18] though it's worth remembering that an absence of evidence is not evidence of absence.

At its peak, the walled city of Dholavira had an area under 0.5 sq. km, slightly larger than Vatican City. It perhaps had a population of 10,000–15,000, and was almost as dense as Delhi today. Interestingly, much of it was for pedestrians only. 'There is no evidence of rut marks on the main streets of Dholavira,' writes Bisht, suggesting that they 'didn't allow bullock carts or any kind of vehicular traffic inside the city'. Rut marks do appear at the entrance gate to the stadium, which may have been from carts conveying goods to a market there, or perhaps participating in sports. Many people must have lived outside the city walls too, especially farmers and herders, likely in homes made of perishable materials. Perhaps artisans as well, who may have come to the city to its workshops and to sell their wares. At least three other Harappan settlements within half-a-day's travel by bullock cart have also been found on Khadir Island.